



Bullet point: A scintillating first-half hat-trick from Real Madrid's Federico Valverde denied Manchester City any chance of making it to the quarterfinal round. REUTERS

in the second. Meanwhile, 18-year-old Dro Fernandez, who switched from Barcelona in the latest transfer window, grabbed his first goal for the Parisians before Warren Zaïre-Emery added the final blow.

PSG's closest challenger, Lens, bounced back from a narrow loss against Lorient and thrashed Angers 5-1 to keep the pressure on. Lens sits second with 59 points from 27 games, one behind PSG, which has a game in hand.

UEFA Champions League

The Premier League's so-called status as the 'toughest league in the world' was dented as four of its six clubs endured heavy defeats in the UEFA Champions League 2025-26 round of 16. Manchester City was up first

against Real Madrid in a fixture that has exhausted players and viewers alike, with the teams meeting in the knockout stage for the fifth straight season. Pep Guardiola's men travelled to the Bernabeu with belief after beating Los Blancos in the league phase earlier this season, but all that confidence was crushed by a scintillating first-half hat-trick from Federico Valverde.

Chasing an unlikely comeback, City battled hard early in the reverse leg at home but was once again undone after Bernardo Silva was given marching orders for stopping Vinicius Jr's on-target shot with his arm. The Brazilian converted from the spot and added another late in the game, while Erling Haaland grabbed a consolation goal to leave the scoreboard reading 5-1 on aggregate.

Tottenham Hotspur and Newcastle United faced similar fates against Spanish opponents Atletico Madrid and Barcelona, respectively. It was a goal fest in Madrid, with Julian Alvarez grabbing a brace as Atletico took a

5-2 lead back to North London.

Despite a much-improved performance at home, Spurs managed only a 3-2 win on the night.

Meanwhile, Newcastle impressed by holding Barcelona to a 1-1 draw at home and carried that form into the second leg, with Anthony Elanga twice restoring parity.

Lamine Yamal then converted from the spot in first-half added time, after which Newcastle's resistance faded. Three goals in the opening 16 minutes of the second half, including a Robert Lewandowski brace, sealed an 8-3 aggregate win for Barcelona.

Defending champion Paris Saint-Germain flexed its muscles as it breezed past Chelsea 8-2 over the two games. While it seemed like the Parisians would only have a one-goal lead to take into the second leg, Khvicha Kvaratskhelia came off the bench to score a late brace and hand his side a 5-2 win. It didn't take long for PSG to put the game to bed in London as Kvaratskhelia and Bradley Barcola scored in the opening 15